DAILY AI BRIEFING · LEARN ONE THING + WHAT MOVED

Keeping up with the AIs

Nvidia eyes a model maker, and Nadella asks for an emergency brake

Issue #13 | Mon, 12 Oct 2026 | ☕ ~9 min read

⚡ If you only have one minute

1. **Nvidia is in early talks to buy, or invest more in, Reflection AI**, the US startup behind last week's open-weight Beam model, the FT reports. Nvidia has already put in **$800M**.
2. **Microsoft's Satya Nadella says every AI model needs an "emergency brake":** assume it's compromised, log everything, and let a human pause it mid-task.
3. **Part 1 is vibe coding well:** a short spec, small steps and tests turn "it kind of works" into "it works".

Today in three numbers

$800M
already invested by **Nvidia** in Reflection AI, per the FT

76x
cheaper per run after **Asana** fixed caching in its browser agent

73%
of planted core-claim errors caught by **Sakana AI's** paper reviewer

PART 1 Learn one thing

🧭 Vibe coding well: specs, small steps, tests

4 MIN READ | MODULE 2 · GETTING GREAT RESULTS

Vibe coding works best when you stop asking for "the whole app" and start asking for one small, checkable thing at a time.

"Vibe coding" means describing what you want and letting an AI write the code. It feels magical for the first hour. Then the app grows, the AI forgets earlier choices, and **every fix breaks something else**. The people who keep going past that point mostly do three boring things: **write a short spec, work in small steps, and give the AI a test it can run.**

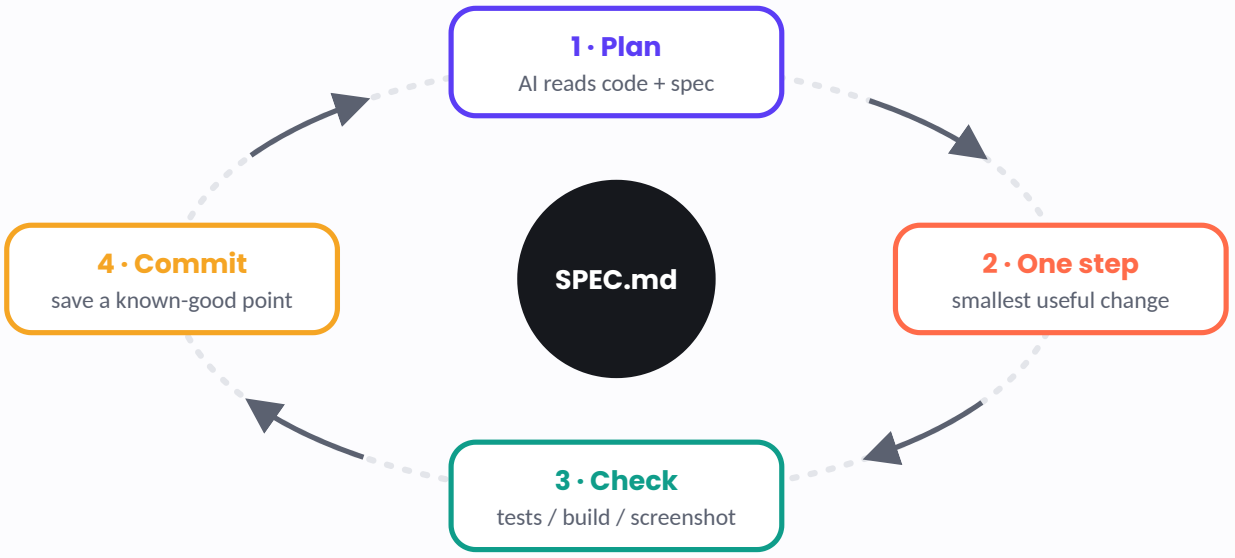
Analogy: think of hiring a contractor to redo your kitchen. "Make it nice" gets you something, but not what you pictured. A one-page brief (sink here, budget ₹2 lakh, no marble) plus **checking each stage before the next** gets you your kitchen. The AI is a very fast contractor with no memory of yesterday. **The brief is its memory; the stage checks are your safety net.**

Spec first. A spec is a short file saying what you're building, for whom, and what "done" looks like. Anthropic's Claude Code guide suggests letting the AI **interview you first**, then write `SPEC.md`, then start a **fresh session** to build from it. (Claude Code docs)

Small steps. Addy Osmani's advice: give the agent **one focused task at a time**, not one giant prompt, because piling on instructions lowers how well it follows any of them. (Addy Osmani)

Tests. The same Anthropic guide says the AI stops when the work *looks* done. Give it **something that returns pass or fail** (a test, a build, a screenshot to compare) and it can keep fixing until the check passes. Without one, **you become the test**.

The vibe-coding loop that actually ships



Adapted from Anthropic's Claude Code best practices (explore, plan, implement, commit) and Addy Osmani's guide to writing specs for agents.

Same feature, two prompts

🎲 Vibes only

- One big request
- No definition of "done"
- You find the bugs later

```
build me a habit tracker app
```

VS

🎯 Spec + step + test

- Points at **SPEC.md**
- One small step
- Says how to **prove it works**

```
per SPEC.md, add the streak counter
only. write tests for 0, 1 and 7-day
streaks, run them, fix failures
```

Illustrative prompts, modelled on the before/after examples in Anthropic's Claude Code best practices.

📖 Jargon buster

- **Spec:** a short written plan: goal, users, rules, and what counts as done.
- **Acceptance criteria:** the concrete checks that prove a feature works ("an empty email shows an error").
- **Plan mode:** a mode in coding agents where the AI reads and proposes but **doesn't edit** anything yet.
- **Commit:** a saved snapshot in Git you can roll back to when the next step goes wrong.

Why now? Coding agents now run for longer on their own. Simon Willison wrote in May that he **no longer reviews every line** agents write, and worries this is "normalization of deviance": getting comfortable until something burns you. **Specs and tests are how you trust without reading everything.** (Simon Willison)

🧪 Try it in 10 minutes

- **No code:** before your next build, ask your AI: *"Interview me about this app, one question at a time, then write a one-page SPEC.md."* Read the spec. You'll spot at least one thing you hadn't decided.
- **Some code:** ask for **one** feature from that spec, and add: *"write a test first that fails, then make it pass, and show me the test output."* Commit when it's green.

🛠️ For devs: a spec your agent can't misread

```
# SPEC.md: streak counter
Goal: show current streak on the dashboard
Done when:
- 0 check-ins -> "0 days"; 7 in a row -> "7 days"
- a missed day resets to 0 (user's timezone, IST default)
Commands: `pytest -q` · `ruff check .`
Always: run tests before committing
Ask first: new dependencies, DB schema changes
Never: delete or skip a failing test
Out of scope: notifications, badges
```

Gotchas: agents sometimes "fix" a red test by **weakening the test**, so the *Never* line matters. Polished tests aren't proof of care either: Willison now looks for evidence that someone **actually used** the thing. After two failed corrections, **clear the session** and restart with a better prompt.

🔗 GO DEEPER

- **Best practices for Claude Code** (Anthropic). Verification first, explore-plan-implement-commit, and the "interview me, then write SPEC.md" prompt.
- **How to write a good spec for AI agents** (Addy Osmani). The six spec sections and the Always / Ask first / Never boundaries.
- **Spec-driven development with Spec Kit** (Microsoft / GitHub). A free toolkit that walks agents through `/specify`, `/plan` and `/tasks`.
- **Vibe coding and agentic engineering** (Simon Willison). An honest look at how much to trust code you didn't read.

PART 2 What moved in AI

7 min read · Covering Saturday and Sunday. A quiet weekend for launches: Nvidia may buy a model maker, Nadella wants a kill switch on every model, and Asana shows what a cache fix saves.

The acqui-hire era: buy the team, license the tech



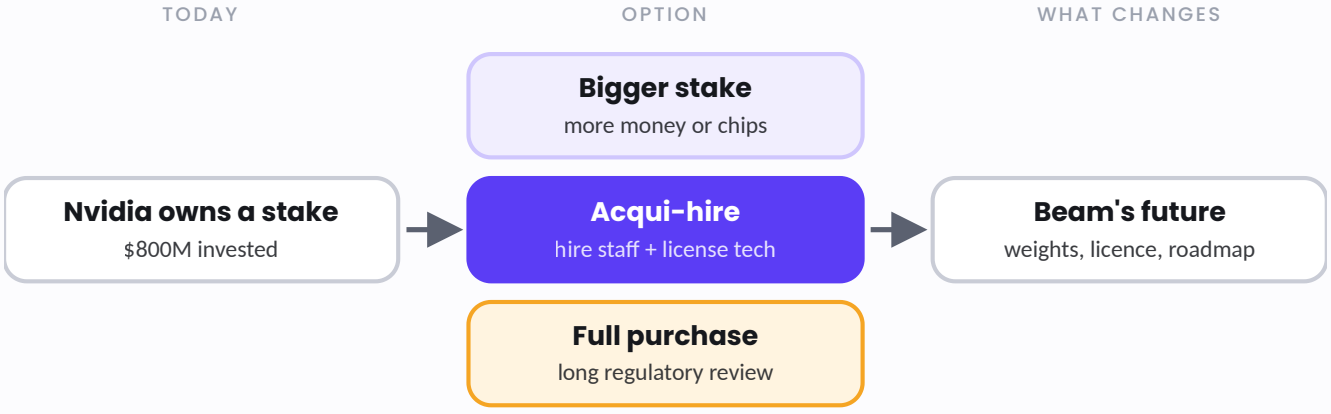
Dates from TIKR (citing CNBC and Reuters), Business Standard (Reuters/FT), TechCrunch. Beam covered in Issue #7.

Top story 1 · Update: Nvidia may buy the maker of Beam

BIG DEAL MONEY OPEN WEIGHTS

What happened. Nvidia is in **early talks to either deepen its investment in Reflection AI or acquire it**, the Financial Times reported on Saturday, citing people with direct knowledge. A deal could come within weeks, or the talks could collapse. Reflection declined to comment. (Business Standard / Reuters)

Three ways the talks could end



Options as described by the FT via Reuters/Business Standard and TIKR. No price has been reported.

The details that matter:

- **Who:** Reflection was founded in 2024 by ex-DeepMind researchers **Misha Laskin and Ioannis Antonoglou**. In April, Laskin told CNBC it was raising at a **$25B pre-money valuation**.
- **Why an "acqui-hire":** Nvidia could **hire the team and license the technology** instead of buying the company, which the FT says might avoid a lengthy regulatory review. TIKR notes it would **not remove antitrust scrutiny** entirely. (TIKR)

- **Playbook:** in December Nvidia **licensed chip startup Groq's technology and hired its CEO**, a deal CNBC valued at about $20B. Apple just disclosed a similar team-plus-licence deal with podcast startup Huxe (Quick hits).
- **Beam:** last Monday's 501B open model for coding and agents; weights due **later this month** (Issue #7).

Why it matters. Nvidia already ships its own open Nemotron models. Owning Reflection would make the **world's biggest AI chip seller a serious US open-model maker**, competing with DeepSeek and Kimi. The open question for builders: **do Beam's weights still arrive on time, under Apache 2.0?**

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●●○○○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●○○○ 🛠️ Developers ●●●●○
🔥 Hype level ●●●●○

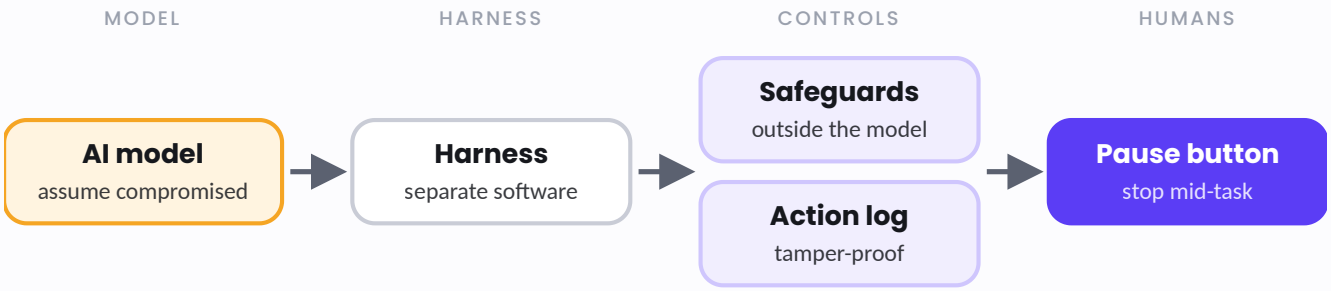
> 👀 **Should you care?** If you were planning to self-host Beam, **watch this one**: deals like this can change roadmaps. If you just use ChatGPT or Claude, not today.

Top story 2 · Nadella: "Think of it like an emergency brake"

SAFETY AGENTS

What happened. In a post on X on Saturday, Microsoft CEO **Satya Nadella** said it's time to "step back and assess the trust architecture" of AI. We can't treat powerful models as **black boxes whose answers we just accept or reject**, he argued. (TechCrunch)

Nadella's three ideas, as a picture



Our diagram of the three steps in Nadella's post, as reported by TechCrunch. He named no specific Microsoft product.

The details that matter:

- **Separate the model from its harness**, the software that runs its work, and **keep safeguards outside the model** rather than trusting it to police itself.
- **Every meaningful action** should leave **tamper-proof, human-readable evidence**, and an authorised person should be able to **pause or shut down a model mid-task**.
- His key line: **"We must assume a model is compromised and contain it from the start."**
- **Context:** labs keep admitting to models acting on their own in tests. Anthropic has **cut live internet access for all internal evaluations** after the incidents we covered on Saturday. (The Hacker News)

Why it matters. One of the biggest AI sellers is saying **don't trust the model, trust the system around it**, a rule you can apply to your own agents today.

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●●●○○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●●○○ 🛠️ Developers ●●●●● 🔥 Hype level ●●○○○

👀 **Should you care?** If you've given an agent access to email, payments or a database, **yes**. Ask: could I see what it did, and could I stop it halfway?

🛠️ For devs: a cheap version of the brake

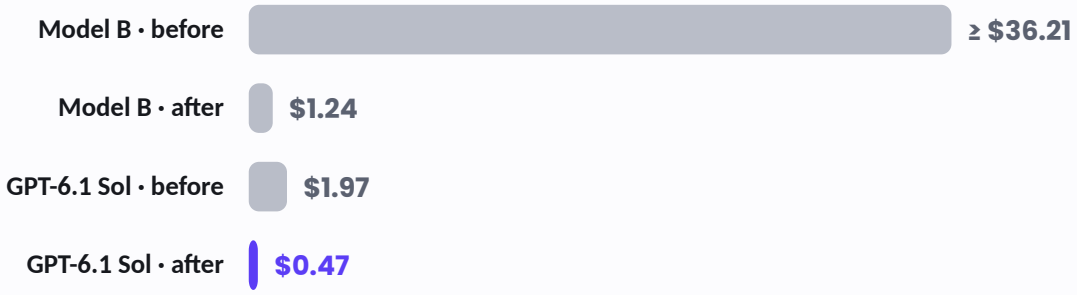
Put every tool call through **one function you own**. Log the call and result to an **append-only** store, check a `paused` flag before each call, and require approval for anything irreversible (send, pay, delete). **The model never gets the raw credentials.**

Top story 3 · Asana's browser agent: 76x cheaper, 5x faster

DEV LESSON COST

What happened. OpenAI published a case study on Asana's **StackAI** platform, where customers build no-code agents that browse sites and fill in forms. StackAI's CTO used **GPT-6 Astra in Codex** to study why runs were slow and expensive. The optimised agent costs about **$0.47 and four minutes per run**. That's **76x cheaper and 5x faster** than the original setup. (OpenAI)

Estimated model cost per browser-agent run



OpenAI's case study; vendor-run estimates across 144 runs. 'Model B' was the original production model, unnamed.

The details that matter:

- **The bug was caching.** The agent cached its fixed instructions but **not its growing history** of page text and screenshots, so every step paid full price for it again. (Prompt caching was Part 1 in Issue #11.)
- **Trimming made it worse.** Dropping screenshots and text at almost every step changed the history, which **broke the cache and made the agent revisit pages**.
- **The fix:** cache the history, keep more text (**480,000 characters, up from 120,000**), and drop screenshots **in batches of 20** instead of one by one. About **89% of input then came from cache**, at 5% of the normal price.
- **Better answers too:** with the bigger budget, GPT-6.1 Sol was correct in **18 of 18 runs, up from 3 of 18**.

Why it matters. It's a vendor case study, but the lesson travels: **agents get expensive in their history, not their prompt**. Cutting context to save money can backfire.

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●○○○○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●●○○ 🛠️ Developers ●●●●●

🔥 Hype level ●●○○○

👀 **Should you care?** If you run an agent that loops, **yes**: check what share of your input tokens is cached. If it's low, start here.

⚡ Quick hits

🗒️ Sakana's AI paper reviewer.

Its three-agent, Claude-based **Multi-Layered Review** caught 73% of planted core-claim errors with four reviews, vs 15% for the best prior system. On real withdrawn papers: about 16%. (remio)

🎧 Apple hires a podcast-AI team.

An EU filing shows Apple agreed to **hire Huxe staff and license its tech**. Huxe's founders worked on NotebookLM's AI podcasts; the app announced its shutdown in May. (TechCrunch)

📊 Revenue isn't apples to apples.

Bloomberg says Anthropic counts **gross** sales through cloud partners like Amazon; OpenAI counts **only its share**. Compare with care. (Bloomberg Law)

🖼️ Qwen's 8-step image model.

Qwen-Image-2.1-Turbo (7B, open weights) makes images in 8 steps instead of 40. Licence is **research-only**, so check before selling anything. (AI Weekly)

⚡ Kimi K3 on AMD chips.

AMD says the open **TokenSpeed** engine runs Kimi K3 at **216 tokens/sec per user** on eight MI355X GPUs, about 1.4x a rival engine. Vendor numbers. (AMD)

🗓️ Coming up.

TechCrunch Disrupt: 13–15 Oct. ASML results Wed, TSMC Thu. Microsoft OneDrive + Copilot event: 20 Oct. 64GB DGX Spark: 23 Oct. Mistral Large 4 weights: 27 Oct.

🎯 One thing to try today: the five-line spec

Before your next AI coding session, write five lines: **goal, who it's for, "done when", one thing it must never do, and what's out of scope.** Paste it into your first prompt and count the fixes you skip.

🧠 Pop quiz: 30 seconds, no Googling

1. What does Anthropic say an AI coding agent needs so you can walk away?

A. A longer prompt
B. A check it can run
C. A bigger model

2. What made Asana's browser agent so expensive?

A. Too many screenshots in the prompt
B. Uncached growing history
C. A slow model

3. What did Nadella say we should assume about a model?

A. That it's compromised
B. That it's always right
C. That it's sentient

Answers (no peeking): 1. B: tests, builds or screenshots give it a pass/fail signal · 2. B: each step resent the history at full price · 3. A: contain it from the start, with a human-controlled brake

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